Q+A

HITTING A HIGH NOTE

Actor, producer and screenwriter ***Neil Nitin Mukesh*** *recently made his OTT debut with the musical drama series* Hai Junoon! Dream. Dare. Dominate



Q. Tell us about your new musical drama series *Hai Junoon! Dream. Dare. Dominate* on JioHotstar.

The show is a coming-of-age tale set in a Mumbai college, where music and dance clubs compete fiercely. I play Gagan Ahuja, a seasoned musician and mentor to the Super-Sonics, who embody discipline and tradition. The series explores themes of ambition, competition and self-discovery, promising an emotional rollercoaster with thrilling performances and nuanced characters.

Q. As the son of Nitin Mukesh and grandson of Mukesh, did you ever consider a career in music?

Playing Gagan allowed me to tap into this musical heritage, and is my homage to my beloved grandfather. In *Hai Junoon!...*, I've had the opportunity to lip sync his iconic song *'Jeena yahan marna yahan'* on screen 55 years after its original release. What could be a better way to feel connected to him and my legacy?

Q. What are your memories of your grandfather? Which song of his is your favourite?

My grandfather passed away before I was born, but my darling grandmother bridged that gap for us kids. She told us numerous stories of his life and journey, which made us feel connected to him. One of my favourite songs by him is *'Kai baar yun bhi dekha hai'* from *Rajnigandha*, for which he won the National Award. His legacy continues to inspire me.

Q. What are you working on next?

My upcoming film is an exciting comic caper thriller that releases in September. Down South, I'm doing a pan-India sci-fi thriller called *MaayaOne* with Sundeep Kishan. It should complete filming sometime soon. As a filmmaker, I continue writing scripts passionately and have an exciting lineup. I'm eager to collaborate with talented creators and bring meaningful stories to audiences.

—with Neha Kirpal